

Top 10 Projected Risers

The evaluation of amateur pitchers is rarely static. Between physical development, role changes, pitch design, improved health, and simple maturation, the landscape can look dramatically different from one year to the next. While rankings attempt to capture where players stand today, some of the biggest gains often come from identifying the arms that possess untapped upside and clear developmental pathways before those leaps become obvious to the rest of the industry.

The 2027 class is particularly intriguing in that regard. It features a deep collection of talented arms spread across a variety of developmental stages. Some have already established themselves as premier prospects but are preparing to take on entirely new responsibilities. Others have flashed high-end traits in shorter looks and now have an opportunity to prove those tools can hold up over larger workloads. Several enter the year healthy after periods of limited availability, while a handful possess ingredients that could suddenly look very different if a single pitch takes a meaningful step forward.

Projecting future risers is not about identifying flaws in current rankings. In many cases, the players on this list are already highly regarded. Instead, it is an exercise in finding the pitchers whose future evaluations may not yet fully reflect the opportunities sitting directly in front of them. Increased innings, expanded roles, improved command, refined secondary offerings, and physical growth can all have a significant impact on how a pitcher is viewed twelve months from now. When talent and opportunity intersect, substantial movement often follows.

This year's group presents a variety of avenues for that type of climb. There are projected starters whose long-term value could spike if they successfully transition into larger workloads. There are relievers who may soon find themselves in premium late-game roles where increased exposure brings increased recognition. There are pitchers whose developmental outlook hinges on the continued growth of a changeup or slider, and others whose stock could rise simply because evaluators finally receive an extended opportunity to see them healthy and competing consistently.

What ties these ten arms together is not identical profiles or identical timelines. Rather, it is the presence of a believable, observable pathway toward a significantly stronger evaluation by the end of the 2027 cycle. For some, that path is tied to stuff. For others, it is tied to role, health, opportunity, or refinement. In every case, however, the foundation is already in place.

These are the ten pitchers I believe are best positioned to elevate their stock and become some of the biggest risers in the 2027 class over the next year. Whether through a breakout season, the emergence of a new weapon, or the chance to finally showcase their abilities on a larger stage, each enters the year with a realistic opportunity to look considerably different by the time the next set of rankings arrives.

Number 10: Zach Edwards, RHP, Oregon State

Few pitchers in the 2027 class possess the combination of raw arm talent and long-term upside that Zach Edwards brings into the year. While many of the names on this list are aiming to refine already-established profiles, Edwards remains one of the more intriguing developmental bets because there is still considerable room between what he is today and what he could ultimately become. The underlying traits are difficult to ignore, and the ceiling remains high enough to envision a substantially different evaluation a year from now.

Edwards' appeal is rooted in projection. The arm talent is evident, the stuff flashes impact potential, and there is still plenty of developmental runway remaining. As he continues to gain experience and refine the finer points of his craft, evaluators will be looking to see how much more consistency can be extracted from an already promising foundation. When pitchers possess this type of physical ability, significant jumps can occur quickly once the pieces begin to come together.

The opportunity ahead only adds to the intrigue. Taking over a prominent bullpen role for a team that is always near the national stage has the potential to put Edwards in front of more evaluators than ever before, and high-leverage relievers often gain momentum rapidly when their talent begins translating into consistent results. With his combination of upside and exposure, he enters 2027 positioned to generate considerable attention.

What makes Edwards such a compelling riser candidate is the amount of unrealized potential still attached to the profile. Many pitchers reach this stage with a relatively clear understanding of what they are. Edwards feels different. There is enough talent, enough projection, and enough developmental upside remaining to believe that his best baseball is still ahead of him. If his arsenal continues to mature and he settles comfortably into a significant role, it would not be surprising to see him emerge as one of the most talked-about bullpen arms in the class by the end of the cycle.

Number 9: Zach Strickland, RHP, UCLA

Few pitchers on this list possess a more intriguing combination of present stuff and future uncertainty than Zach Strickland. In many ways, that uncertainty is exactly what makes him such a compelling riser candidate. Entering 2027, evaluators can reasonably envision two very different outcomes: a starter capable of handling meaningful innings for one of the nation's premier pitching staffs, or a dominant late-inning weapon whose arsenal plays at an elite level in high-leverage situations.

Regardless of role, the foundation is the same. Strickland's appeal begins with the quality of his stuff. The arsenal features the type of raw weapons that consistently attract evaluator attention, and his ability to miss bats gives him a ceiling that extends well beyond his current placement. Whether deployed for multiple innings or shorter stints, the stuff is impactful enough to project success in a variety of roles.

What makes his profile particularly fascinating is that each developmental path carries significant upside. If he ultimately settles into a starting role, he will have the opportunity to prove the arsenal can hold up across larger workloads against high-level competition. Success in that environment would dramatically expand his overall profile and likely elevate how evaluators view his long-term value. At the same time, if he lands in the bullpen full-time, there is reason to believe the stuff could become even more dangerous, allowing him to emerge as one of the premier closers in the class.

Opportunity is another major factor. Being part of one of the country's most talented pitching staffs ensures that meaningful innings will come on a prominent stage. Whether those innings arrive as a starter or in the back end of games, Strickland is positioned to gain substantial exposure against quality opponents throughout the year.

Ultimately, his riser potential stems from the fact that the talent is already evident while the role remains unresolved. There are not many pitchers in the class who can realistically project as either a high-impact starter or an elite closer. That flexibility, combined with the quality of the arsenal, gives Strickland one of the wider ranges of outcomes among the arms on this list. If the role crystallizes and the stuff performs the way I believe it can and did in 2026, a significant jump in his overall standing would not be surprising.

Number 8: Landon Mack, RHP, Tennessee

Landon Mack enters 2027 with one of the clearest opportunities in the class to elevate both his profile and long-term projection. Projected to take on a prominent role in Tennessee's rotation, likely as the program's Friday night starter, Mack is positioned to pair premium arm talent with the kind of workload and visibility that can dramatically alter a player's evaluation over the course of a season.

The foundation is already in place. Mack possesses a physical frame, upper-tier velocity, and some of the best raw spin characteristics in the class. His sinker routinely operates in the mid-90s and reaches triple digits, giving him a power weapon capable of overwhelming hitters on velocity alone. More importantly, he maintains that velocity deep into outings, allowing the pitch to remain effective as a starting weapon rather than simply a short-burst bullpen offering.

His long-term outlook is driven by the quality of his secondary arsenal. Both the slider and cutter flash as legitimate weapons, with the slider serving as the primary put-away pitch. The combination gives him multiple options against right-handed hitters and allows him to miss bats at a high rate when he is ahead in counts. The spin profile throughout the arsenal is particularly impressive, creating confidence that further refinement could unlock even more effectiveness from the breakers.

What makes Mack such an intriguing riser candidate is that there are still several areas where meaningful gains appear realistic. Improved sinker command, particularly to the glove side, would open up additional sequencing possibilities and make the entire arsenal play up. Continued development of the changeup would provide a more complete answer against left-handed hitters, while additional refinement of the curveball could further deepen an already impressive pitch mix.

The ingredients of a quality collegiate starter are evident. Mack already possesses the velocity, durability, and three-pitch foundation evaluators seek in rotation pieces, and there is a reasonable path toward even more arsenal depth. If the command takes a step forward and he successfully handles a frontline role for one of the nation's premier programs, the conversation could shift quickly from dependable rotation piece to one of the more interesting starting pitching prospects in the class. His upside is ultimately tied to how much polish he can add, but the raw material gives him a chance to make a substantial jump over the next year.

Number 7: Kyle Alivo, RHP, Iowa

Kyle Alivo earns a place on this list because his path to a higher evaluation is less about a dramatic overhaul and more about the natural progression of an already intriguing pitching profile. The foundation is in place. The arm talent is evident. The arsenal is deep. As he continues to mature physically and gain experience, there is a strong case that the overall package could take a meaningful step forward.

What stands out most about Alivo is the diversity of his pitch mix. Many young pitchers are still searching for a reliable secondary offering or trying to prove they can navigate a lineup multiple times. Alivo already possesses the type of arsenal depth that allows evaluators to envision a long-term starting role. The ability to mix pitches, change looks, and attack hitters in different ways gives him more avenues to succeed than many of his peers.

That arsenal depth is supported by quality arm talent. The delivery works, the ball comes out cleanly, and the raw stuff provides a strong platform for future growth. He does not need a complete reinvention of his profile to rise significantly. Instead, the focus is on refinement, consistency, and allowing his physical tools to continue developing. Those types of improvements often produce some of the largest gains because they impact every part of a pitcher's game rather than a single offering.

There is also value in recognizing how much development can occur simply through age and experience. Additional strength, improved body control, a better understanding of sequencing, and enhanced command can elevate an entire arsenal. When a pitcher already possesses multiple usable weapons, those gains tend to compound. Better command makes every pitch play up. Improved confidence allows a deeper mix to be utilized more aggressively. Increased physical maturity can unlock another level of stuff without changing the overall identity of the pitcher.

For Alivo, the appeal is not tied to one specific pitch taking a dramatic leap or a major role change creating new visibility. His case is built around the idea that a talented pitcher with a diverse arsenal and considerable developmental runway still has room to grow into the full version of himself. If those expected gains arrive over the next year, he has the tools to emerge from 2027 as a significantly more complete and highly regarded prospect than he is today.

Number 6: Wylan Moss, RHP, UCLA

Wylan Moss enters 2027 with many of the difficult questions already answered. He has a path to a starting role, he owns multiple established weapons, and he has demonstrated the type of arm talent required to navigate a collegiate rotation. The next step is not building a starter profile from the ground up. Instead, it is refining an already promising foundation and pushing his arsenal to a higher level.

The biggest reason Moss appears on this list is the combination of present ability and realistic developmental upside. His fastball and primary secondary offering already give him two pitches that can consistently win against quality hitters. That is an important starting point because it allows his future growth to focus on enhancing an existing strength rather than searching for one. Evaluators already know there is legitimate stuff in the profile.

The most intriguing development to monitor is the continued progression of his slider. A step forward from that pitch could significantly change the overall outlook of the arsenal. When pitchers already possess multiple quality weapons, the emergence of another dependable bat-misser can have an outsized impact on the profile. It creates more sequencing options, improves effectiveness against different hitter types, and increases confidence that the stuff can turn a lineup over multiple times.

Just as important, Moss appears positioned to receive the opportunity necessary to prove it. A full-season starting role provides a much different evaluation environment than shorter outings or sporadic usage. More innings create greater exposure, more chances to demonstrate durability, and more opportunities to show that the arsenal can maintain effectiveness throughout extended workloads.

What makes Moss such an appealing riser candidate is that the leap does not require a dramatic transformation. The arm talent is already there. The foundation of the pitch mix is already there. The opportunity is arriving. If the slider becomes the weapon many believe it can be and the overall arsenal continues to mature, Moss has a realistic path to emerging as one of the more complete starter prospects in the class by the end of the cycle.

Number 5: Cole Gibler, LHP, Arkansas

Cole Gibler earns his place among the top projected risers because the foundation for a much higher-profile starter already exists. Left-handed pitchers with legitimate arm talent and multiple impact offerings are always going to draw attention, and Gibler enters 2027 with an opportunity to elevate his stock significantly if the rest of the arsenal continues to develop around an already impressive core.

The profile starts with a pair of pitches capable of carrying a starter's workload. His fastball and primary secondary give him a combination that can challenge hitters from both sides of the plate and generate swings and misses against quality competition. The overall look is reminiscent of a lighter version of Cole Carlon: a left-hander whose success is driven by arm talent, pitch quality, and the ability to lean heavily on two standout weapons. Like Carlon, Gibler's best pitches already provide a strong baseline for success even before the entire arsenal reaches maturity.

What makes him such an appealing riser candidate is that there is still another level available. The continued development of his changeup has the potential to alter the profile dramatically. Starter evaluations often change quickly when a pitcher moves from having two trusted weapons to possessing a legitimate third pitch capable of neutralizing opposite-handed hitters. That type of growth not only improves performance but also strengthens confidence in the long-term starter projection.

The opportunity ahead only enhances the outlook. Gibler has a chance to assume a larger role and face the type of workload that allows evaluators to determine how the arsenal holds up over extended outings. With the arm talent already in place and two established pitches capable of missing bats, the developmental focus becomes refinement rather than reinvention.

Among the left-handers in the class, Gibler offers one of the more attractive combinations of present stuff and future projection. If the changeup takes the step many are anticipating and the overall arsenal continues to mature, he has the ability to make a substantial move up boards over the next year. The ingredients for a significant rise are already present, making him one of the more compelling breakout candidates in the 2027 cycle.

Number 4: Matthew Shorey, LHP, Vanderbilt

Matthew Shorey lands on this list for a simple reason: evaluators still have not seen the full version of the player. Health interrupted opportunities to build momentum, limiting both exposure and the ability to establish consistency, but the flashes that have been shown are enough to make him one of the more intriguing bounce-back candidates in the class.

The appeal starts with the stuff. Even in limited looks, Shorey has shown the type of arsenal that attracts attention from scouts and evaluators. The raw ingredients are already present, and unlike some riser candidates whose cases are built almost entirely on projection, Shorey has provided real evidence of what the profile can look like when he is at his best. That makes betting on a rise much easier because the foundation has already been established.

Health is ultimately the biggest variable. A full season of availability would allow him to do something he has not consistently been able to do: stack outings, build momentum, and give evaluators an extended look at the complete package. For talented pitchers, sometimes the largest jump comes not from adding velocity or developing a new pitch, but from simply getting on the field and remaining there.

The situation around him only adds to the upside. Pitching at a nationally recognized program creates visibility that many talented arms never receive. Strong performances against high-level competition are noticed quickly, and a healthy Shorey will have every opportunity to put himself back into major conversations. Exposure matters, and there are few better places to generate it than on a prominent staff competing on one of college baseball's biggest stages.

What makes Shorey such a compelling riser candidate is the combination of existing stuff, unanswered questions, and renewed opportunity. The talent has already flashed. The platform is already in place. If he is finally able to stay healthy and show evaluators a full season of what he can do, there is a realistic path for him to make one of the largest jumps in the class over the next year.

Number 3: Sean Jenkins, RHP, ECU

Sean Jenkins enters 2027 with one of the most obvious opportunities to climb boards, not because evaluators are suddenly going to discover him, but because they may finally see him in a role that fully showcases the quality of his arsenal. The talent is already evident. The question is whether an expanded workload allows that talent to be viewed through a different lens.

At the center of Jenkins' profile is one of the better sinker-slider combinations in the class. The sinker gives him a power foundation capable of generating weak contact and controlling at-bats early, while the slider serves as a legitimate swing-and-miss weapon that can finish hitters when he gets ahead. Together, the two pitches form the type of pairing that allows pitchers to dominate in high-leverage situations and creates a difficult look for hitters throughout an outing.

What makes Jenkins especially intriguing is how well those pitches complement one another. Hitters are forced to respect the power and movement of the sinker, creating uncomfortable swings and rushed decisions, only to then contend with a slider that operates on a completely different plane. The combination creates pressure and gives Jenkins multiple ways to win against quality competition.

The biggest reason he appears this high on the list is opportunity. An increased role would allow evaluators to see more innings, more high-leverage situations, and more chances for the arsenal to impact games. Sometimes a player rises because the stuff gets better. Other times, the industry simply gets a larger sample of an already impressive player. Jenkins feels like a candidate for the latter.

There is also room for the profile to continue evolving. As he gains experience and continues refining his overall approach, the existing strength of the sinker-slider foundation provides a platform for further growth. When a pitcher already possesses two pitches capable of carrying an outing, even modest improvements elsewhere in the arsenal or command profile can have a substantial impact on the overall evaluation.

The appeal of Jenkins is straightforward. He has the arm talent, he has the weapons, and he appears poised for a larger stage. If the workload expands and the sinker-slider combination performs the way many expect it to, he has a realistic chance to finish 2027 viewed as one of the premier power arms in the class.

Number 2: Sam Cozart, RHP, UT

Sam Cozart possesses the type of upside that can change an evaluation quickly once the role catches up to the talent. So far, his development has been as an elite closer. Entering 2027, however, the focus shifts toward a far more intriguing possibility: the transition from high-end bullpen arm to legitimate starting pitching prospect.

The physical foundation immediately stands out. Cozart brings the frame evaluators want to see in a starter, with the size, athleticism, and durability projection necessary to handle a larger workload. Those traits matter because they create confidence that the arm talent can eventually be stretched over meaningful innings rather than being confined to late-game appearances. When projecting future risers, physicality is often one of the biggest indicators of untapped upside, and Cozart checks that box in a major way.

The opportunity at Texas only amplifies the excitement. Moving from a closer profile into a potential starting role at one of college baseball's premier programs creates a pathway for both increased production and increased visibility. Every inning carries more weight when it comes against elite competition and on one of the sport's biggest stages. If Cozart successfully claims and holds a rotation spot, evaluators will have far more opportunities to assess the complete profile.

What makes him such a compelling riser candidate is that the developmental questions are largely centered around usage rather than talent. The arm strength is already there. The athleticism is already there. The raw ingredients that made him an exciting bullpen arm also happen to be the traits that give him a chance to become something more. The transition simply requires proving those tools can maintain their effectiveness across multiple trips through a lineup.

There may not be a larger potential value swing in the class than a successful move from closer to starter. High-end relievers are valuable, but durable starters with Cozart's physical traits and arm talent occupy a completely different tier of prospect status. If he proves capable of handling a full starter's workload while maintaining the quality of his stuff, his stock could climb dramatically over the course of the 2027 season. Among the arms in this class, few have a clearer path toward a substantially different evaluation by year's end.

Number 1: Easton Hawk, RHP, UCLA

Easton Hawk sits atop this list because no arm in the class combines present talent, long-term projection, and developmental upside quite like he does. He already possesses many of the traits evaluators search for in frontline starters, yet there is still enough room for growth in both his frame and arsenal to believe his best baseball remains ahead of him. If the transition into a full-time starting role unfolds as expected, Hawk has a chance to make one of the most significant jumps in the entire 2027 class.

The physical foundation is a major part of the appeal. Hawk has the build teams want to see in a starter, with the strength to handle innings today and the remaining projection to continue adding to an already impressive frame. That combination creates confidence in his ability to maintain his stuff over longer outings while still leaving open the possibility of another step forward physically.

The arm talent is even more difficult to ignore. Hawk's velocity already ranks among the best in the class, giving him a power foundation that immediately stands out. Premium velocity is valuable on its own, but what separates Hawk is the belief that it can hold in a starting role. Starters capable of missing bats while maintaining elite velocity deep into games are always viewed differently, and Hawk possesses the type of arm strength that creates that possibility.

Beyond the raw stuff, there is a competitive presence on the mound that consistently draws evaluators in. Hawk pitches with confidence, attacks hitters aggressively, and carries himself with the mentality teams want to see from a rotation leader. Those traits do not show up on a radar gun or in a pitch model, but they matter when projecting who can successfully handle the responsibilities that come with front-end innings.

The arsenal itself only adds to the excitement. There is a realistic path toward a five-pitch mix, giving Hawk significantly more weapons than many pitchers at this stage of development. The ability to attack hitters with multiple looks, mix speeds, and sequence different pitch shapes creates a foundation for long-term success as a starter. As those secondary offerings continue to mature, the overall profile becomes increasingly difficult to match within the class.

What makes Hawk such an obvious riser candidate is that the upside is not tied to one specific change. He can improve through physical development. He can improve through refinement of the pitch mix. He can improve through the added exposure and workload that comes with starting. Most importantly, he already possesses the arm talent necessary to capitalize on those opportunities. If the starter transition progresses as expected and the arsenal continues moving toward its full potential, Hawk has every opportunity to emerge from 2027 as one of the premier pitching prospects in the country.

Conclusion

Projecting future risers is one of the most challenging exercises in amateur scouting because player development rarely follows a predictable path. Some pitchers add velocity. Others refine an existing weapon into a true out pitch. Sometimes a role change unlocks untapped value, while in other cases simply staying healthy and accumulating innings allows evaluators to fully appreciate a player's talent. The common thread is that significant jumps rarely happen by accident. They are usually built upon traits that already exist beneath the surface.

That reality is reflected throughout this group. Easton Hawk and Sam Cozart represent two of the most intriguing starter-transition candidates in the class, with the physicality, arm talent, and arsenals to dramatically elevate their value if they successfully handle larger workloads. Sean Jenkins and Zach Strickland already possess the type of stuff that can dominate quality competition, but expanded opportunities could bring increased exposure and greater recognition. For Matthew Shorey, the opportunity to put together a healthy season may be the most important development of all.

Elsewhere, pitchers such as Cole Gibler, Wylan Moss, and Kyle Alivo highlight how quickly evaluations can change when a talented arm begins converting potential into consistency. Gibler's continued changeup development, Moss' pursuit of another weapon alongside an already strong foundation, and Alivo's deep pitch mix combined with natural growth all provide believable pathways toward a significantly stronger profile. Landon Mack, meanwhile, enters the year positioned to take on one of college baseball's most visible roles, while Zach Edwards and Zach Strickland could see their stock soar as high-leverage weapons with premium stuff.

Ultimately, this list is not an attempt to predict exactly where these pitchers will rank twelve months from now. Instead, it is a reflection of who appears best positioned to outperform current expectations. Whether through improved health, expanded responsibilities, arsenal development, physical growth, or a successful move into the rotation, each of these arms has a clear avenue toward becoming a much different pitcher by the end of the 2027 cycle.

The 2027 class already features impressive pitching talent, but history suggests the arms drawing the most attention next year will not be identical to the names dominating conversations

today. When talent, opportunity, and development converge, substantial jumps follow. These ten pitchers possess as much potential as anyone in the class to make that leap and emerge as some of the biggest risers in the country over the next year.